While Shah Shuja was being installed in the Bala Hisar, its previous occupant, Dost Mohammad Khan, was fleeing north as fast as he could. Like Shah Shuja after the Battle of Nimla thirty years earlier, the loss of power immediately changed everything for him, and brought with it a series of humiliations which nearly resulted in his ruin and death.

The Barakzais struggled with difficulty over the icy passes, in headlong flight from the British trackers who had been sent out to hunt them down. Yet Dost Mohammad could not move with any real speed as he was 'accompanied by a throng of wives, infants, brothers, sons, and servants'.[25] His heir Akbar Khan, moreover, was still recovering from the poison apparently administered to him at the Khyber, possibly on Wade's orders. Unable to ride, he had to be carried on a litter. The Afghan epic poets remembered the flight of Dost Mohammad with as much sympathy as their Scottish counterparts romanticised that of Bonnie Prince Charlie after Culloden. 'Then forward went the brave sovereign,' wrote Ghulam Kohistani in his *Jangnama*,

> And with him a thousand courageous cavalry.
>
> And behind them passed the harem
> Remembering the old custom
>
> After him came the chattels and gold
> And vigilant sentries, ever watchful
>
> On their trail, with feet like lightning,
> Travelled the vengeance-seekers
>
> Both night and day they rode
> Like clouds that rush across the sky[26]

The tracking party was led by two tough and resourceful young officers, James Outram and George Lawrence, who were given Haji Khan Kakar and a thousand of Shah Shuja's cavalry as their guides and escort. Travelling at speed, it should not have been difficult to ride down the slow-moving Barakzai caravan. Yet, for all their efforts, Outram's party never succeeded in capturing the Amir, and it soon became clear that Haji Khan was as usual playing a double game, deliberately leading the British off the trail and doing all he could to slow the pursuit.